

AFP

"Once I started to understand the rules, there was this unlimited beauty in chess. But I'm still learning..."

Q. How are you handling the spotlight after the win?
There are two sides to it, obviously. The positive is that the more attention this win creates, the better it will be for chess and the players, for more sponsors to come in. I am very happy to play a part in that. After winning the title in Singapore, I thought I would come back to India and there would be some nice events and we would go back to normal. But it is nothing like what I imagined, to be honest. Sometimes you do get annoyed, especially when people come to the house.

Q. Top GMs like Hikaru Nakamura, Anish Giri, and even Magnus have taken to playing and analysing games as streamers. Do you see yourself being a part of the wave?
I think streamers and content creators are great for chess. Even before the chess boom happened during the pandemic, Hikaru was bringing people to the game through his streams. ChessBase India and a lot of comedians have helped create this awareness and it's great what they are doing for chess. I am comfortable on camera and I can do interviews, but streaming—talking to myself and playing chess—is a bit weird. I really don't see myself getting into it.

Q. There was criticism about the quality of play at the World Championship...
I knew Magnus was analysing the games on the TakeTakeTake app. Some of my team members were listening in, and got some insights from it. Critics had a point but because of my age I think it's easier for things to fire me up and I want to prove them wrong. Throughout my career, criticism has been a source of motivation for me. I believe nobody can criticise me the way I do myself. ■